

10.6 Google Talk

10.6.1 Introduction

Like Gmail, this instant messaging client was a late entrant to the arena. Compared to the other IM clients, Google Talk (GT) is extremely lean. Continuing on the sparse interface of Gmail, GT does away with the bloat that has become associated with IM clients. No checking weather or stock quotes or playing games while using GT!

10.6.2 Using Google Talk

After installing GT, on logging in for the first time, you will see that the contacts list is already populated. This is because GT borrows the address book from Gmail. The contacts need not be all Gmail users. You can change the contact list behaviour by clicking on the View button at the bottom of the IM windows. To see only Gmail users, deselect the “Show All Address book Contacts” option. Online contacts have a green circle to their left and an “Available” subscript. Even if the contact is only using Gmail’s Standard with Chat interface, the status will be “Available”—but you cannot use voice in this case.

Setting your own status is simple, and as discussed elsewhere, you can also set it to the current track your media player is playing.

Besides the Contact list, you can see the Add and View contacts button at the bottom and a Settings link at the top. That’s all the client sports. Compared to the bells and whistles on other IM clients, GT seems to be on a starvation diet.

Starting an IM session is simple—double-clicking on any of your online friends opens a chat box. Type a message and press [Enter] for it to be sent across. Unlike other IM clients, you will not be able



Google Talk’s view options



Changing status in GT